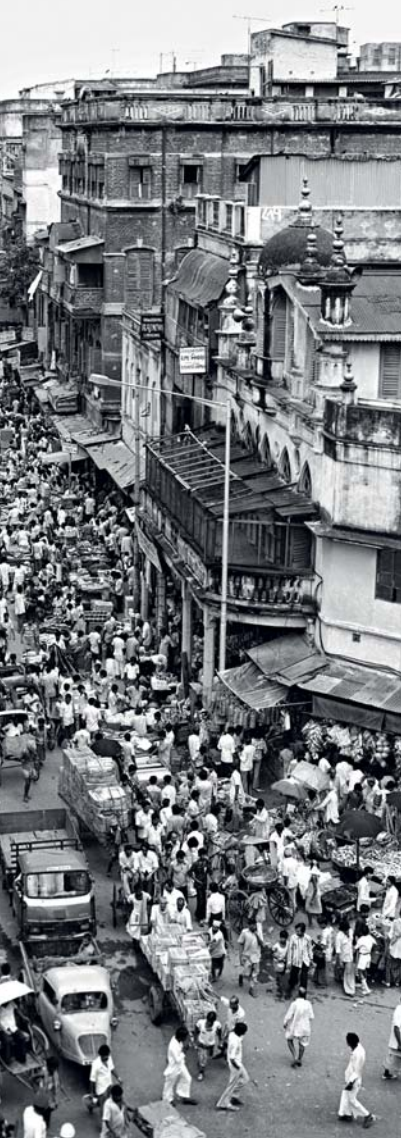
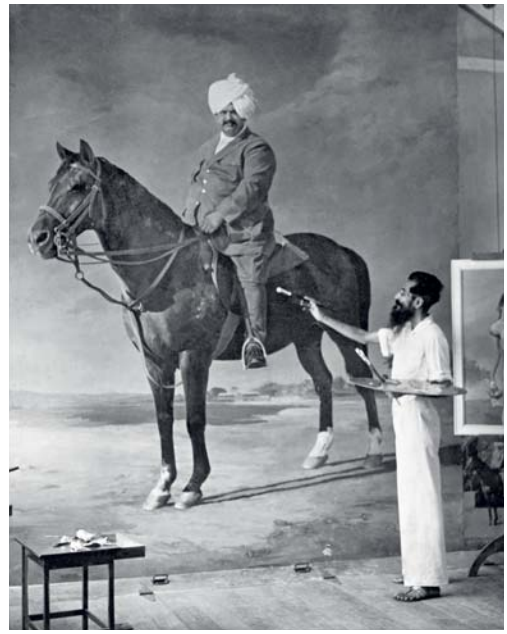
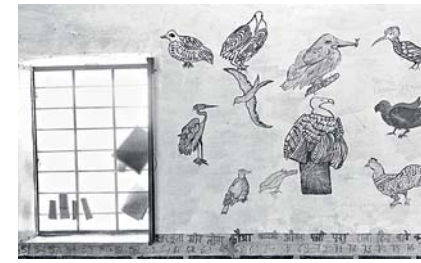




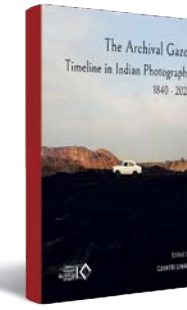


IN CAMERA
Clockwise from far left: 'Canning Street' by Salim Paul; Baburao Painter in his studio; 'The Mark on the Wall' by Gauri Gill; from 'Deliverance' by Atul Bhalla; 'Kaha-Bird' by Sheba Chhachhi





THE ARCHIVAL GAZE: A Timeline of Photography in India, 1840-2020, Volume 2
by Gayatri Sinha (Editor) KIRAN NADAR MUSEUM OF ART
₹4,700; 440 pages



sucks in the medium's developments, its refracting processors push out to the world very different kinds of photography and ways of reading and using photographs than is found elsewhere. As Rahab Allana writes in his essay, "Photography from the Indian subcontinent has challenged and transformed both the general and specialist reception of this dynamic medium over the past 150 years." The 20th century sees photography branch out crazily, not least in what Allana calls 'image deployment and viewership', forming jugalbandis with all sorts of projects—from the production of fictional and mythological images to the nationalist movement, i.e. the creation of the nation itself. The late 20th century and the first two decades of the 21st see a further diversification, bringing us to both the ubiquitous selfie/ Insta era and the *bohurupiya* photo-based image popping up in every quadrant of the art world.

A photographer friend once described a gathering of fellow practitioners as 'a quibble of photographers', so it is unavoidable that these twin slabs, beautifully conceived and produced as they are, raise some push and pull of aperture. The ability of a photograph to mean totally different things to different people kicks up again when you read about "a striking image of a wealthy man seated in a rickshaw being pulled by an impoverished rickshaw puller": looking at the described photograph by William Gedney, most people from Calcutta would see a riksha-walla hauling a lower-middle class babu. At a deeper level, it seems quite a conceptual stretch when a scholar tries to corral Sheba Chhachhi's powerful, multilayered work *Winged Pilgrims* and her monumental *Temporal Twist* into a 'queer optic'.

If there is one essay or recounting missing from the book, it is about how the sheer scarcity and expense of imported photographic material between 1950 and 1990 directly affected the way people made photographs in India. (Gedney, we are told, comes to Banaras in 1970 and exposes *350 rolls* of film in about 18 months—more than many Indian photographers would have exposed in their entire careers).

A typical quandary for overview volumes of this type is that with Partition, the practices in the neighbouring countries, (anyway totally absent vis-a-vis Ceylon/ Sri Lanka and Nepal) Pakistan and Bangladesh, become invisible, shrinking a subcontinental study of over 100 years to a national one for the past 75.

Finally, as intended, these volumes are indeed indispensable for the understanding of photography in India, but at Rs 9,400 for the pair, they are sadly completely beyond the reach of any ordinary scholar or photographer. ■

–Ruchir Joshi